

Identity & Naming Workbook

Legal Name Architecture, Public Identity, Candidate Matrix & Selection Workflow

Version 0.4 | September 19, 2026

[[LEGAL_CORPORATE_NAME]] / [[PUBLIC_COMMUNITY_NAME]]

Pre-filing working draft. Counsel/CPA and future Board review required before legal or tax submission. Not legal or tax advice.

Purpose

Move naming from brainstorming to a controlled institutional decision without forcing a premature legal identity.

v0.4 Selected Baseline - Provisional Organizational Decisions

These are design defaults for drafting. They do not become legally operative until adopted/filed by the appropriate persons.

Topic	Working decision	Why
Tennessee corporation type	Public benefit religious nonprofit corporation	Intended religious, educational and charitable purposes serve public rather than mutual/private benefit.
Statutory members	No statutory members at formation	Avoids creating a corporate electorate before a real community exists; participant rights remain protected by charter/bylaws/policies.
Board	5-seat formation target; 7-11 mature board; $\geq 2/3$ independent mature board	Tennessee minimum is 3; stronger internal standard distributes power and supports founder accountability.
Founder	Founder + President/Executive Director + Director	Separates historical founder status from corporate sovereignty while allowing operational leadership.
Chair	Independent person other than Founder/President	Prevents executive and board oversight from collapsing into one office.
Secretary	Separate person from President	Tennessee law requires President and Secretary and forbids one person from holding both offices simultaneously.
Treasurer	Prefer independent/separate person	Financial authority should not be concentrated with spiritual/executive authority.
Federal application	Full Form 1023	Provides a detailed record appropriate to a complex religious/educational/charitable organization.
Initial public-charity class	509(a)(1)/170(b)(1)(A)(vi), subject to actual funding model	Intended reliance on donations/grants/public support is compatible with this classification; verify projections before filing.
Church classification	Defer until actual congregation/services/government/worship facts exist	IRS applies a facts-and-circumstances church analysis and generally expects a congregation or religious membership group meeting for worship.
Founder compensation	Initially unpaid except policy-compliant expense reimbursement; later prospective reasonable compensation after independent approval	Avoids self-dealing while preserving a path to legitimate paid full-time leadership.
Fiscal year	December 31	Selected by Founder.
Filing sequence	Prepare -> recruit board -> select name -> counsel review -> file TN charter -> organize -> EIN -> banking -> Form 1023 -> public launch	Reduces avoidable amendments and avoids launching high-risk programs before controls exist.

Identity & Naming Architecture

Objective

Choose a name that can serve a serious religious community, research/publication institution, charitable organization, clergy/formation program, and eventually a physical community without sounding denominational, grandiose, authoritarian, or artificially ancient.

Recommended naming architecture

Use a **same-root two-level architecture** unless a later reason emerges to create separate legal entities:

- **Legal corporation:** [[PUBLIC_NAME]], Inc. or another counsel-approved legal form using the same distinctive root.
- **Public/community name:** [[PUBLIC_NAME]].
- **Descriptive line:** a non-legal descriptor such as *A community of worship, inquiry, service, and formation.*
- **Programs:** research institute, publications, benevolence program, retreat program, clergy formation, and eventual residential/community programs can carry subordinate program names.

This is simpler and more transparent than creating a neutral corporation whose relationship to a differently named religious community is hard for donors or participants to understand.

Name tests

A serious candidate should pass all of the following:

1. **Tradition-transcending:** does not imply that the organization is merely a church, synagogue, mosque, temple, monastery, or a branch of an existing denomination.
2. **Religiously meaningful:** does not sound like a consulting firm, software company, political organization, or academic center only.
3. **Inquiry-compatible:** permits genuine research, historical criticism, doubt, and revision rather than implying possession of final truth.
4. **Community-compatible:** can name people who gather, worship, learn, serve, and care for one another - not merely a website or journal.
5. **Non-authoritarian signal:** avoids language of chosen elites, hidden grades, masters, unquestionable revelation, absolute truth, remnant identity, or founder possession.
6. **Plain pronunciation:** understandable when heard once and easy to spell/search.
7. **Expandable:** still works if the organization later has local assemblies, clergy, publications, schools/programs, retreats, property, and charitable work.
8. **Legally distinct:** Tennessee requires the corporate name to be distinguishable on the Secretary of State's records and prohibits misleading claims of affiliation/sponsorship.
9. **Digitally distinct:** reasonable domain/search availability after final candidate screening.
10. **Trademark-aware:** final selection receives a trademark/conflict check beyond a general web search.

Terms to use carefully

Terms such as *church*, *synagogue*, *mosque*, *temple*, *ecclesia/ekklesia*, *masjid*, and *sangha* carry valuable histories but also signal a specific tradition or institutional form. They can appear in comparative study or local program language without becoming the umbrella identity.

Words such as *order*, *elect*, *remnant*, *master*, *final revelation*, *one true*, *initiates*, and similar exclusivist/graded-authority terms should not be adopted merely to make a young religion sound ancient or authoritative.

Naming workflow

1. Select 3-5 finalists from the candidate matrix.
2. Test each aloud in sentences: "I attend __," "__ published this report," "__ provides pastoral care," "__ is raising funds for land," and "__ removed its founder from office under its bylaws."
3. Run Tennessee entity-name search and reserve only after a finalist is chosen.
4. Run federal/state trademark screening and common-law web search.
5. Check domain/social availability.
6. Conduct a small outside perception test with people who know nothing about the project.
7. Choose legal/public spelling and create a naming-resolution record.

Tennessee facts relevant to naming

Current Tennessee law requires a nonprofit corporate name to be distinguishable on the Secretary of State's records and restricts language that falsely implies affiliation or authorization. A name can currently be reserved for four months. The Tennessee Secretary of State currently lists a \$20 name-reservation fee and a \$100 domestic nonprofit charter filing fee. Re-check immediately before filing.

Name Candidate Matrix - Working Round 1

This is a **creative and collision-screening worksheet**, not trademark or legal clearance. The web screen was performed September 19, 2026.

Candidate	Institutional fit	Strength	Main caution	Limited web-screen status
Assembly of Sacred Inquiry	Religious community + research + worship	Clearly combines communal gathering with disciplined inquiry	"Sacred Inquiry" is used by an existing religion/spirituality blog; exact full phrase did not surface prominently	**Advance to finalist screen**
Community of Sacred Inquiry	Community-forward, less hierarchical	Warm and accessible	Same "Sacred Inquiry" root collision; sounds slightly less like an organized religious body	**Advance to finalist screen**
House of Sacred Inquiry	Physical/digital religious house + scholarship	Scales well to a place and institution	"House" may imply a physical site before one exists	**Advance to finalist screen**
Shared Horizon Assembly	Plural perspectives under one community	Strong metaphor for inquiry without doctrinal closure	"Shared Horizon" is used in consulting/other contexts; less explicitly religious	**Advance with caution**
Open Horizon Assembly	Openness, transcendence, future orientation	Neutral across traditions	May sound educational/civic rather than religious	**Advance with caution**
Threshold Assembly	A community at the boundary between traditions and inquiry	Distinctive and memorable	"Threshold assembly" is also an industrial phrase; "threshold" can sound esoteric	**Secondary candidate**
Fellowship of Sacred Inquiry	Community and shared practice	Warm	"Fellowship" reads Christian to many U.S. audiences	**Secondary candidate**
The Sacred Commons	Shared sacred life	Strong concept	Already used by an active church/community and other projects	**Do not advance**
The Common Assembly	Neutral communal term	Simple	Existing U.S. 501(c)(3) uses this exact name	**Do not advance**
Open Sanctuary	Welcoming spiritual place	Strong public meaning	Multiple active religious/spiritual organizations use it	**Do not advance**
Common Sanctuary	Shared religious refuge	Strong concept	Existing religious community uses it	**Do not advance**

Current working leader

Assembly of Sacred Inquiry is the strongest **working** candidate because "assembly" describes a gathered people without committing the project to a single inherited institutional form, while "sacred inquiry" preserves the project's commitment to religious seriousness and continuing investigation.

It should remain a working candidate until Tennessee name, trademark, domain, and broader common-law screening are completed.

Alternative architecture if the final community name is more poetic

If a highly symbolic public name is later chosen, the legal entity can still use a transparent descriptive form such as:

[[DISTINCTIVE_NAME]] Religious and Charitable Corporation, Inc.

while publicly using [[DISTINCTIVE_NAME]]. Counsel should confirm the final legal suffix/style and whether an assumed-name filing is needed.

Open Decisions Register - After v0.4

Decisions the Founder must ultimately make or help make

Identity

- ☐ Select 3-5 name finalists.
- ☐ Select final public/legal name after clearance.

People

- ☐ Identify at least two additional directors (legal minimum).
- ☐ Preferably identify four additional directors (formation target).
- ☐ Identify a Secretary separate from the President.
- ☐ Identify independent Chair candidate.

Activities

- ☐ Confirm which listed programs are genuinely planned for the first 12-24 months rather than aspirations.
- ☐ Confirm worship/gathering format and expected frequency.
- ☐ Confirm whether children's programming is planned before or after Form 1023 filing.
- ☐ Decide whether ordination is an early program or later-stage program.
- ☐ Keep housing/intentional-community work in development stage until a concrete legal model exists.

Money

- ☐ Complete initial three-year budget assumptions.
- ☐ Confirm expected fundraising channels and whether fees will be charged for any programs.
- ☐ Determine when a salaried Founder/President role becomes financially feasible; the Board, not Founder, sets the amount.

Filing

- ☐ Insert registered/principal office immediately before Tennessee filing.
- ☐ Obtain counsel review of charter/bylaws and high-risk programs.
- ☐ After incorporation, obtain EIN and finalize Form 1023 evidence.

Decisions intentionally **not** required yet

- exact future land/property location;
- detailed residential community rules;
- final church classification;
- a permanent worship building;
- a mature clergy hierarchy;
- a complete long-term doctrine;
- a seven-person board on day one, provided Tennessee's minimum and the formation plan are satisfied.

Current Source Notes - v0.4

Checked: September 19, 2026. Re-check before filing.

Tennessee

- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-52-102 (2025), Charter - public/mutual benefit status, religious-corporation statement, registered agent/office, incorporator, principal office, nonprofit statement, member/nonmember statement, dissolution provisions: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-52/section-48-52-102/>
- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-54-101 (2025), Corporate name - distinguishability and restrictions on false affiliation/sponsorship: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-54/section-48-54-101/>
- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-54-102 (2025), Reserved name - four-month reservation: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-54/section-48-54-102/>
- Tennessee Secretary of State Business Forms & Fees - current list shows \$20 nonprofit name reservation and \$100 nonprofit charter filing: <https://sos.tn.gov/businesses/forms-and-fees>
- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-58-103 (2025) - board must have at least three natural persons: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-58/part-1/section-48-58-103/>
- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-58-104 (2025) - nonmember corporation directors elected/appointed/designated as charter/bylaws provide: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-58/part-1/section-48-58-104/>
- Tenn. Code Ann. § 48-58-401 (2025) - every nonprofit has a President and Secretary; same individual cannot simultaneously hold both: <https://law.justia.com/codes/tennessee/title-48/nonprofit-corporations/chapter-58/part-4/section-48-58-401/>

IRS

- Instructions for Form 1023 - activities narrative, financial projections, public-charity classifications, church Schedule A, compensation/conflicts: <https://www.irs.gov/instructions/i1023>
- Form 1023 narrative details: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-detail-required-in-narrative-description-of-activities>
- Form 1023 required financial information: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-required-financial-information>
- Form 1023 compensation/financial relationships: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-required-information-about-compensation-and-other-financial-information>
- Form 1023 conflict-policy purpose: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-purpose-of-conflict-of-interest-policy>
- Form 1023-EZ instructions - applicant seeking church recognition is ineligible for 1023-EZ: <https://www.irs.gov/instructions/i1023ez>
- Form 1023 user fee - currently \$600, paid through Pay.gov; subject to change: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-and-1023-ez-amount-of-user-fee>
- Public charity classification overview: <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/determine-your-foundation-classification>

Limited public-name collision screen

General web searches identified active/current use of "The Common Assembly," "The Sacred Commons," "Open Sanctuary," "Common Sanctuary," and "The Sacred Inquiry." This is not a trademark or Tennessee-entity clearance and is only a reason not to prioritize those exact identities.